שדולת הנשים בישראל
لوبي النساء في إسرائيل
The Israel Women's Network

The Alice Line:
Emergency Expansion During the Iran War

Overview

The Israel Women's Network (IWN) is launching an emergency expansion of **The Alice Line**, Israel's national women's rights response center, in order to address the urgent needs of women during the current war with Iran. Since the escalation began just days ago, Israel has returned to full emergency mode: schools are closed indefinitely, only essential workers may report to work, and tens of thousands of reservists have again been called to military service. In this environment, women across Israel are experiencing immediate disruptions to their employment, caregiving responsibilities, and economic stability.

The Alice Line was established during the war that began in October 2023 as a national support and policy platform to help women navigate emergency regulations, access their rights, and address systemic gaps in government responses. The Alice Line is much more than a hotline: it functions as both a **direct assistance center and a policy intelligence hub**, allowing IWN to identify emerging problems in real time and advocate for policy changes before discriminatory or harmful systems become entrenched.

With the outbreak of the new war with Iran, the need for this work has intensified dramatically. In just the first three days of the current escalation, the Alice Line received **the equivalent of an entire month's volume of calls** - nearly **ten times our normal rate**. Women are calling with urgent questions about employment rights, childcare obligations, unpaid leave, small business collapse, and benefits for families of reservists. These calls reveal both the human toll of war and the systemic policy gaps that must be addressed immediately.

Rachel's story

Rachel is a 34-year-old mother of two young children. When the war with Iran began, schools and childcare facilities in her area were closed due to ongoing rocket attacks and emergency regulations. At the same time, her partner was called back to reserve duty after already serving more than 300 days during the war in Gaza. Overnight, Rachel found herself alone at home with two small children and no childcare options.

Yesterday, the Ministry of Finance announced that parents whose children cannot attend school may take unpaid leave (halat) during the emergency period. Rachel was unsure what this meant in practice. If she took unpaid leave in order to stay home with her children, would she be entitled to compensation? What were her rights vis-à-vis her employer? And how could she ensure her family would still have income while her partner was serving in the reserves?

Our legal team explained her rights under the emergency regulations and what taking unpaid leave would mean in practice. Based on our experience during the previous operation with Iran, we warned Rachel that employees who initiate unpaid leave themselves are often not eligible for compensation; in many cases, compensation is granted only when the employer places the worker on unpaid leave.

We therefore advised her on the steps she should take with her employer and clarified the level of compensation she may be entitled to receive.

In addition, our team informed Rachel about financial grants for partners of reservists - benefits she had not known she was eligible for - and assisted her in submitting the necessary applications.

Rachel's story is not unique. It reflects the systemic challenges facing women across Israel right now:

- Women are pushed out of work when schools and childcare systems close indefinitely
- Self-employed women and small business owners see income disappear overnight
- Partners of reservists manage households alone while navigating employment instability
- Women in precarious employment lose shifts and have few protected rights
- Emergency regulations are drafted rapidly without gender lens
- Women facing violence at home are locked in 24/7 in danger
- Women without safe rooms are in the most danger of all

The Solution

In order to support women, IWN is expanding the Alice Line to meet this unprecedented demand while simultaneously strengthening its role as a national policy intervention mechanism. The Alice Line operates at two levels:

(1) **Support: Providing direct legal and bureaucratic assistance** to women across Israel in multiple languages on employment rights during emergency shutdowns, reserve-spouse benefits, compensation eligibility, and other urgent issues.

(2) **Advocacy:** Collecting real-time information about women's needs and experiences to enable our legal and policy teams to intervene quickly with government ministries, the Civil Service Commission, and the Knesset to correct discriminatory policies and close legal gaps.

(3) **Protecting women in the workplace.** Creating written and visual guidelines to educate employers and ensure that they protect their employees' rights during the war emergency.

In other words, the Alice Line does not merely respond to individual crises - it transforms those crises into **systemic policy change**.

The IWN track record

This model has already proven highly effective. During the previous phase of the war, information gathered through the Alice Line led directly to several significant policy changes, including:

- Expanding eligibility for childbirth allowances for women serving in reserve duty
- Ensuring employment protections for partners and co-parents of reservists
- Securing economic benefits for workers from evacuated communities
- Correcting discriminatory regulations that excluded women from key compensation

Now, as the war with Iran unfolds, IWN must rapidly expand this infrastructure in order to continue protecting women's rights in real time.

Request

To meet the urgent needs created by the current escalation, the Israel Women's Network seeks support to expand the Alice Line's emergency response capacity.

Funding will allow IWN to:

- Expand hotline capacity to handle the surge in calls
- Increase legal staffing to provide immediate guidance on employment and rights
- Strengthen policy advocacy with government ministries as emergency regulations are drafted
- Expand multilingual outreach so women across Israel know where to turn for help
- Develop accessible webinars and digital resources explaining women's rights

At a moment when Israeli society is under extraordinary strain, the Alice Line ensures that women are not left to navigate the crisis alone. By providing both direct support and systemic advocacy, the project protects women's economic stability, safeguards their legal rights, and strengthens Israel's democratic commitment to equality even in times of war.

Your support will enable us to respond immediately to the surge in need and to continue fighting for women like Rachel - ensuring that their safety, livelihoods, and rights are protected in the midst of national emergency.

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